

## BEYOND THE TEXTBOOK · GUIDE 01

# Build Your Portfolio Page

A personal website in HTML and CSS that looks good on phones and laptops.

|                                                            |                                                             |
|------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>TIME NEEDED</b><br>45–60 minutes                        | <b>LEVEL</b><br>Beginner                                    |
| <b>YOU NEED</b><br>A computer, Chrome or Edge, and VS Code | <b>STARTER FILES</b><br><code>examples/01-portfolio/</code> |

## WHAT YOU WILL BUILD

A one-page portfolio with your name, an About section, three project cards, a contact form, and a footer.

It uses only HTML and CSS, works on phones, and can go live for free with GitHub Pages (Guide 04).

## Before you start

A portfolio is your online introduction. Colleges, internship recruiters and clients can open one link and see what you have built. This guide takes the starter portfolio and turns it into **your** portfolio.

| File                    | What it does                                                                          |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <code>index.html</code> | The content and structure of the page: headings, text, images, links, and the form.   |
| <code>style.css</code>  | The look of the page: colours, fonts, spacing, and the layout for phones and laptops. |
| <code>script.js</code>  | Sends the contact form and shows a “Thank you!” message on the page (Step 9).         |

## Step 1 Install a code editor

Download **Visual Studio Code** (free) from [code.visualstudio.com](https://code.visualstudio.com) and install it with the default options.

Then add the **Live Server** extension. It opens your page in the browser and refreshes it every time you save.

1. In VS Code, click the **Extensions** icon on the left (four small squares), or press `Ctrl + Shift + X`.
2. Search for **Live Server** (by Ritwick Dey) and click **Install**.

## Step 2 Get the starter files

**Option A: from the starter repository.** Open the workshop repository on GitHub, click the green **Code** button, then **Download ZIP**. Unzip it and find `examples/01-portfolio/`.

**Option B: from scratch.** Create a folder called `my-portfolio`. Inside it, create two empty files named `index.html` and `style.css`, then copy the complete code from the **Appendix** at the end of this guide.

### BE CAREFUL

File names matter. Use lowercase letters and no spaces: `index.html`, not `Index.HTML` or `my page.html`. GitHub Pages treats `Photo.png` and `photo.png` as different files.

## Step 3 Open the page

1. In VS Code choose **File** → **Open Folder...** and open your portfolio folder.
2. Right-click `index.html` and choose **Open with Live Server**.
3. Your browser opens the page at an address like `http://127.0.0.1:5500`. Keep this tab open.

### TIP

No Live Server? Simply double-click `index.html` in your file explorer. You will need to press F5 in the browser after each save.

## Step 4 Understand the structure

Open `index.html`. The page is divided into clear blocks using **semantic tags**. These tags tell the browser, screen readers and Google what each part means.

| Tag                                                    | Section on the page                           | What to change                                              |
|--------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| <code>&lt;head&gt;</code>                              | Hidden settings: title, description, CSS link | Your name in <code>&lt;title&gt;</code> and the description |
| <code>&lt;header&gt;</code> + <code>&lt;nav&gt;</code> | Top bar with logo and menu links              | The logo text                                               |
| <code>&lt;section class="hero"&gt;</code>              | Big welcome area                              | Your name and one-line tagline                              |
| <code>&lt;section id="about"&gt;</code>                | About you and your skills                     | Your story and skills list                                  |
| <code>&lt;section id="projects"&gt;</code>             | Three project cards                           | Project names, text, images, links                          |
| <code>&lt;section id="contact"&gt;</code>              | Contact form                                  | Your Formspree ID (Guide 02)                                |
| <code>&lt;footer&gt;</code>                            | Bottom line                                   | Your name and year                                          |

### GOOD TO KNOW

The menu links work by ID. `<a href="#projects">` jumps to the element with `id="projects"`. If you rename an ID, change the link too.

## Step 5 Add your own details

Change the page title and description first. This is the text Google shows in search results.

### index.html — inside <head>

```
<title>Asha Patil | Student Web Developer</title>
<meta name="description" content="Portfolio of Asha Patil, a 12th standard
  student learning web development. See my projects and get in touch.">
```

Next, replace the sample name, tagline and About text with your own. Edit the skills list by adding or removing `<li>` lines:

### index.html — About section

```
<ul class="skills">
  <li>HTML5</li>
  <li>CSS3</li>
  <li>Responsive Design</li>          <!-- add your own skills -->
</ul>
```

Save with `Ctrl + S`. Live Server refreshes the browser for you.

## Step 6 Add your projects and images

1. Create a folder named `images` next to `index.html`.
2. Take a screenshot of each project (`Windows + Shift + S` on Windows) and save it into `images`, for example `images/quiz.png`.
3. In each project card, change the image path, the title, the description and the link.

### index.html — one project card

```
<article class="card">
  
  <h3>Quiz App</h3>
  <p>A 10-question quiz that shows your score at the end.</p>
  <a href="https://your-username.github.io/quiz/" class="link">View project &rrarr;</a>
</article>
```

### TIP

Always write a useful `alt` text. It describes the image for visually impaired visitors and helps Google understand your page. “Screenshot of my quiz app” is better than “image1”.

### GOOD TO KNOW

The starter uses placeholder pictures from `placeholder.co` so the page looks complete. Replace them with your own screenshots before you publish.

## Step 7 Change the colours

All colours are stored as **CSS variables** at the top of `style.css`. Change a value once and it updates everywhere.

### style.css — top of the file

```
:root {
  --navy: #0B2E59;    /* header, footer, headings */
  --blue: #0B5FBF;    /* buttons and links */
  --cyan: #00B4D8;    /* small highlights */
}
```

Find colour codes with the colour picker at [htmlcolorcodes.com](https://htmlcolorcodes.com). Keep text dark on light backgrounds so it stays easy to read.

## Step 8 Test on a phone-sized screen

Most visitors will open your site on a phone. The starter is **mobile-first**: the normal CSS rules are for phones, and the `@media (min-width: 768px)` rule at the bottom of `style.css` changes the layout on bigger screens (three project cards side by side).

1. In Chrome or Edge, press `F12` to open Developer Tools.
2. Press `Ctrl + Shift + M` to switch on the device toolbar.
3. Pick a phone such as **iPhone 12 Pro** or **Pixel 7** from the list at the top and scroll through your page.

### BE CAREFUL

Never delete this line from `<head>`: `<meta name="viewport" content="width=device-width, initial-scale=1.0">`. Without it, phones show a tiny zoomed-out desktop page.

## Step 9 Connect the contact form

The contact form already points to Formspree. Follow **Guide 02** to create a free Formspree form, then replace `YOUR_FORM_ID` in this line with your own ID:

### index.html — Contact section

```
<form class="contact-form" action="https://formspree.io/f/YOUR_FORM_ID" method="POST">
```

After you click Send message, you should see a green “Thank you! Your message has been sent.” message appear under the button, and the page should not reload. This works the same way as the contact form in Guide 02, using the same script.js pattern.

## Step 10 Publish it

Follow **Guide 04** to upload the folder to GitHub and switch on GitHub Pages. Your portfolio will be live at an address like `https://your-username.github.io/my-portfolio/`.

**ASK AN AI HELPER (Claude, Gemini, Copilot or Antigravity)**

“Explain what each section of this index.html does, line by line, for a beginner.”

“Suggest a professional colour palette for a student portfolio and give me the CSS variables.”

“My project cards stay in one column on a laptop. Here is my CSS. What is wrong?”

“Add a 'Certificates' section to my portfolio that matches the existing card style.”

After the AI answers, read the code, paste it in, save, and test it on a phone-sized screen. If you do not understand a line, ask the AI to explain it.

## Troubleshooting

| Problem                           | Likely cause and fix                                                                                                                                |
|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| The page has no colours or layout | <code>style.css</code> is not linked. Check <code>&lt;link rel="stylesheet" href="style.css"&gt;</code> and that both files are in the same folder. |
| An image does not appear          | The path or file name is wrong. <code>images/Quiz.PNG</code> and <code>images/quiz.png</code> are different. Match the name exactly.                |
| Menu link does not jump           | The <code>href="#..."</code> value does not match the section <code>id</code> .                                                                     |
| Page looks tiny on a phone        | The viewport <code>&lt;meta&gt;</code> line is missing from <code>&lt;head&gt;</code> .                                                             |
| Changes do not show               | You did not save ( <code>Ctrl + S</code> ), or the browser is showing an old copy. Press <code>Ctrl + F5</code> .                                   |

## Final checklist

- ☐ My name is in the `<title>`, the hero section and the footer.
- ☐ The description `<meta>` describes me in one or two sentences.
- ☐ Each project card has my own title, text, screenshot, link and a useful `alt` text.
- ☐ I tested the page on a phone-sized screen.
- ☐ The contact form has my Formspree ID (Guide 02).
- ☐ There are no personal details I would not want strangers to see (home address, phone number).

## Appendix: complete code

### index.html

```
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html lang="en">
<head>
  <!-- 1. Basic page settings -->
  <meta charset="UTF-8">
  <!-- This line makes the page fit phone screens -->
  <meta name="viewport" content="width=device-width, initial-scale=1.0">

  <!-- 2. SEO: what Google shows in search results -->
  <title>Asha Patil | Student Web Developer</title>
  <meta name="description" content="Portfolio of Asha Patil, a 12th standard student
learning web development. See my projects and get in touch.">

  <!-- 3. Link to the CSS file that styles this page -->
  <link rel="stylesheet" href="style.css">
</head>
<body>

  <!-- ===== HEADER + NAVIGATION ===== -->
  <header class="site-header">
    <a href="#top" class="logo">Beyond the<span> Textbook</span></a>
    <nav aria-label="Primary">
      <a href="#about">About</a>
      <a href="#projects">Projects</a>
      <a href="#contact">Contact</a>
    </nav>
  </header>

  <main id="top">

    <!-- ===== HERO (first thing visitors see) ===== -->
    <section class="hero">
      <p class="kicker">Hello, I'm</p>
      <h1>Asha Patil</h1>
      <p class="tagline">12th standard student from Pune. I build simple, useful websites
with HTML, CSS and JavaScript.</p>
      <a href="#projects" class="btn">See my projects</a>
    </section>

    <!-- ===== ABOUT ===== -->
    <section id="about" class="section">
      <h2>About me</h2>
      <p>I started learning web development in school with HTML and CSS. Now I build small
projects every week and publish them online with GitHub Pages.</p>
      <ul class="skills">
        <li>HTML5</li>
        <li>CSS3</li>
        <li>JavaScript</li>
        <li>Git & GitHub</li>
        <li>Formspree</li>
        <li>Supabase</li>
      </ul>
    </section>

    <!-- ===== PROJECTS (3 cards in a grid) ===== -->
    <section id="projects" class="section">
      <h2>My projects</h2>
      <div class="projects">

        <article class="card">
          <!-- alt text describes the image for screen readers and Google -->
```

```

        
        <h3>Quiz App</h3>
        <p>A 10-question general knowledge quiz that shows your score at the end.</p>
        <a href="#" class="link">View project &arr;</a>
    </article>

    <article class="card">
        
        <h3>Contact Form</h3>
        <p>A contact form that sends messages to my email using Formspree.</p>
        <a href="#" class="link">View project &arr;</a>
    </article>

    <article class="card">
        
        <h3>Class Guestbook</h3>
        <p>Visitors leave a message and everyone can read it. Data is saved in
Supabase.</p>
        <a href="#" class="link">View project &arr;</a>
    </article>

</div>
</section>

<!-- ===== CONTACT (form powered by Formspree) ===== -->
<section id="contact" class="section">
    <h2>Contact me</h2>
    <p>Have a question or an idea? Send me a message.</p>

    <!-- Replace YOUR_FORM_ID with your own ID from formspree.io (see Guide 02) -->
    <form id="contact-form" class="contact-form"
action="https://formspree.io/f/YOUR_FORM_ID" method="POST">
        <label for="name">Your name</label>
        <input type="text" id="name" name="name" required>

        <label for="email">Your email</label>
        <input type="email" id="email" name="email" required>

        <label for="message">Message</label>
        <textarea id="message" name="message" rows="4" required></textarea>

        <button type="submit" id="send-btn" class="btn">Send message</button>
        <p id="form-status" role="status"></p>
    </form>
</section>

</main>

<!-- ===== FOOTER ===== -->
<footer class="site-footer">
    <p>&copy; 2026 Asha Patil &middot; Built with HTML &amp; CSS &middot; Hosted on GitHub
Pages</p>
</footer>

<script src="script.js"></script>
</body>
</html>

```

**script.js**

```

// =====
// Formspree: send the contact form with JavaScript (no page reload)
// Without this file, the form still works: the browser goes to
// Formspree's own "Thanks!" page instead.
// =====

```

```

const form = document.getElementById("contact-form");
const button = document.getElementById("send-btn");
const statusText = document.getElementById("form-status");

form.addEventListener("submit", async function (event) {
  event.preventDefault(); // stop the normal page change

  if (form.action.includes("YOUR_FORM_ID")) {
    showStatus("Setup needed: replace YOUR_FORM_ID in index.html with your Formspree form ID.", "error");
    return;
  }

  button.disabled = true;
  button.textContent = "Sending...";

  try {
    const response = await fetch(form.action, {
      method: "POST",
      body: new FormData(form),
      headers: { Accept: "application/json" } // ask Formspree for a JSON reply
    });

    if (response.ok) {
      showStatus("Thank you! Your message has been sent.", "success");
      form.reset();
    } else {
      const data = await response.json();
      const reason = data.errors ? data.errors.map(e => e.message).join(", ") : "Please try again.";
      showStatus("Sorry, something went wrong: " + reason, "error");
    }
  } catch (error) {
    showStatus("Network problem. Check your internet connection and try again.", "error");
  }

  button.disabled = false;
  button.textContent = "Send message";
});

function showStatus(message, type) {
  statusText.textContent = message;
  statusText.className = type;
}

```

### style.css

```

/* =====
Portfolio styles
Mobile-first: the basic rules are for phones.
The @media rule at the bottom adjusts the layout for
bigger screens (tablets and laptops).
===== */

/* 1. Colours stored in variables so you can change them in one place */
:root {
  --navy: #0B2E59;
  --blue: #0B5FBF;
  --cyan: #00B4D8;
  --grey: #5B6B7C;
  --light: #F5F9FD;
  --border: #D7E4F0;
}

/* 2. Reset: remove default browser spacing */

```

```

* {
  box-sizing: border-box;
  margin: 0;
  padding: 0;
}

html { scroll-behavior: smooth; }

body {
  font-family: Arial, Helvetica, sans-serif;
  color: var(--navy);
  line-height: 1.6;
  background: #FFFFFF;
}

img { max-width: 100%; display: block; }

/* 3. Header and navigation */
.site-header {
  display: flex;
  flex-wrap: wrap;
  justify-content: space-between;
  align-items: center;
  gap: 10px;
  padding: 16px 20px;
  background: var(--navy);
  position: sticky; /* header stays on top while scrolling */
  top: 0;
  z-index: 10;
}

.logo {
  color: #FFFFFF;
  font-weight: bold;
  font-size: 1.3rem;
  text-decoration: none;
}

.logo span { color: var(--cyan); }

nav a {
  color: #CFE6F5;
  text-decoration: none;
  margin-left: 16px;
  font-size: 0.95rem;
}

nav a:hover { color: #FFFFFF; }

/* 4. Hero section */
.hero {
  padding: 60px 20px;
  background: var(--light);
  text-align: center;
}

.kicker { color: var(--cyan); font-weight: bold; letter-spacing: 2px; text-transform: uppercase; }
.hero h1 { font-size: 2.4rem; margin: 6px 0 12px; }
.tagline { color: var(--grey); max-width: 560px; margin: 0 auto 24px; }

/* 5. Buttons */
.btn {
  display: inline-block;
  background: var(--blue);
  color: #FFFFFF;
  padding: 12px 24px;
  border: none;
  border-radius: 8px;
  font-size: 1rem;
  text-decoration: none;
  cursor: pointer;
}

```

```

}
.btn:hover { background: var(--navy); }

/* 6. General section spacing */
.section {
  padding: 50px 20px;
  max-width: 1000px;
  margin: 0 auto;
}
.section h2 { font-size: 1.8rem; margin-bottom: 12px; }
.section > p { color: var(--grey); margin-bottom: 20px; }

/* 7. Skills as small pills */
.skills {
  list-style: none;
  display: flex;
  flex-wrap: wrap;
  gap: 10px;
}
.skills li {
  background: #E8F7FB;
  border: 1px solid var(--border);
  border-radius: 20px;
  padding: 6px 14px;
  font-size: 0.9rem;
}

/* 8. Project cards: one column on phones */
.projects {
  display: grid;
  grid-template-columns: 1fr;
  gap: 20px;
}
.card {
  background: var(--light);
  border: 1px solid var(--border);
  border-radius: 12px;
  overflow: hidden;
}
.card h3, .card p, .card .link { margin: 0 16px; }
.card h3 { margin-top: 14px; }
.card p { color: var(--grey); font-size: 0.95rem; }
.card .link {
  display: inline-block;
  margin-bottom: 16px;
  color: var(--blue);
  font-weight: bold;
  text-decoration: none;
}

/* 9. Contact form */
.contact-form {
  display: flex;
  flex-direction: column;
  gap: 8px;
  max-width: 520px;
}
.contact-form label { font-weight: bold; font-size: 0.95rem; }
.contact-form input,
.contact-form textarea {
  padding: 10px 12px;
  border: 1px solid var(--border);
  border-radius: 8px;
  font-size: 1rem;
  font-family: inherit;
}
.contact-form button { margin-top: 10px; align-self: flex-start; }
#form-status { min-height: 1.5em; font-weight: bold; }
#form-status.success { color: #1E8E5A; }
#form-status.error { color: #C0392B; }

```

```
/* 10. Footer */
.site-footer {
  text-align: center;
  padding: 24px;
  background: var(--navy);
  color: #CFE6F5;
  font-size: 0.9rem;
}

/* 11. Bigger screens (768px wide and above): 3 project cards side by side */
@media (min-width: 768px) {
  .hero { padding: 90px 20px; }
  .hero h1 { font-size: 3.2rem; }
  .projects { grid-template-columns: repeat(3, 1fr); }
}
```

## About the Instructor

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